

Pay special attention to your knees and monitor them for signs of pain or discomfort. “No pain, no gain” definitely does not apply to these complex joints. If you need to, prop them up with pillows when you are sitting to take the strain off the ligaments. If they feel tender when you kneel on them in weight-bearing positions, support them with some form of padding. Straighten them out of a bent-leg position if it feels uncomfortable. If one of the knees refuses to straighten, as it might in the Lying hamstring stretch (see p.65), use a towel, belt, or strap to reach the foot.

You can increase or decrease the intensity of a stretch as it suits you (perhaps your body feels different on different days or at different times of day) by pulling or extending more or less. Breathing and relaxing help you stretch farther. Alternatively, try modulating the intensity of a stretch by elongating in a progression from one to ten, and then reducing it. The level of intensity should never go into the “strain zone” and you should not have extreme pain after you have performed your stretches. Remember: compare only yourself to yourself to make the greatest gain.

Help for different stretches. A towel over the toes acts as a strap for a hamstring stretch—elastic exercise bands don’t work so well. A book under the pelvis (right, above) will help you to sit forward on the sit bones. A rolled up towel placed under the head straightens the neck and helps you avoid neck pain (right, center). A towel is excellent as padding when you are kneeling (right, below).

